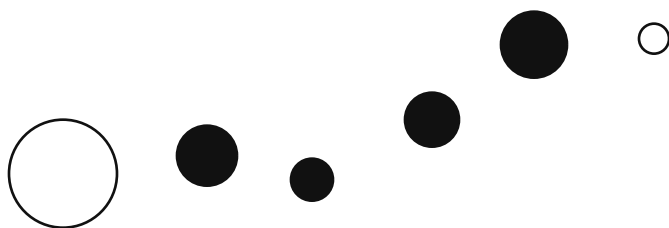


Papier Bleu



No. 1

JANUARY 2015

PROSE POETRY

Papier Bleu

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Ten writers on memory and omission

MASTHEAD

Founder & Editor-in-Chief

Kristil Rabideau

Papier Bleu is an independent student magazine. It is not an official publication of Columbia University, and the views expressed belong to the writers.

Contributors are listed on pages 17 and 18.

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INTERESTED IN SUBMITTING?

Send works no longer than 500 words, in the form of prose poetry. If you are looking for clarity, the best example is Italo Calvino's *Invisible Cities*, or this issue.

Send your work to rabideaukristil@gmail.com.

Please title your email "Papier Bleu Submission" for easy finding.

THE PROVISIONS OF LATE

Mira S. · GS '16

In Verenne the provisions arrive after the winter they were meant for. The city keeps four storehouses.

The first holds bread baked for guests who have already left. It is stacked by date of departure, and it is still warm, because the bakers are very good.

The second holds coal for the cold of a year ago. The old women of Verenne sit beside it and feel its heat in their hands and say, yes, that was a hard one.

The third holds umbrellas for rains that were moved to other cities. Once a year they are opened indoors, to let the weather remember them.

The fourth is empty, and is the best guarded. Here are kept the things the city meant to buy and did not: the lamp, the long coat, the word for what you felt at the station. The keeper says the shelves are full of the right sizes.

Travelers ask how Verenne survives. It has never run short of anything, they are told. Everything simply comes to it already remembered.

LATE TIDE

Samir T. · CC '16

At Corvane the sea arrives a day after the moon that called it, so that the fishermen who go down to the harbor at dusk find the water of yesterday standing at the steps, grey and a little embarrassed, with the boats of last month still tied to it, and the boys who run along the quay to meet the tide are met instead by the tide's memory of boys, who ran along the same quay in the same shoes and ask the same question, which is whether the water has come for the nets or for the people who mended them, and the answer, which the old harbor-master gives only to those who have stayed past the third bell, is that the sea has never come for anything, that it merely returns to the places where it was once held, the way you return to a room to find what you were looking for and stand there with your hand on the door, remembering only that it was something you needed, and the tide comes in, late, to stand beside you, and neither of you says what it was.

THE ALMANAC OF WINTER

Clara K. · CC '16

From the almanac of Tamsin, printed each year for the year before.

JANUARY 3. Snow, of the kind that falls upward. Expect a visitor you have already forgotten. Good for sleeping.

JANUARY 19. A thaw. The clocks of the lower town will run backward until noon. Do not sign anything.

FEBRUARY 2. The longest night in the memory of the house. It will be shortened by those who were awake for it.

FEBRUARY 14. Letters will arrive from the dead, unsealed, and mostly about the weather.

MARCH 1. The ice on the river will speak. It will say a name. It is probably yours; it is probably spelled wrong.

MARCH 21. Spring is announced, by tradition, to a city that has not been told winter ended. Plant nothing. Remember everything.

Note from the compiler: these predictions are drawn from the weather of the previous year, and have been right every year but one.

THE LETTER OF BORROWED

Ilana M. · CC '18

Dear [],

I am writing from the city you lent me. I have kept it well. I have walked its [] each evening and hung its [] out to dry. I have borrowed, as you said I might, its mornings, though they are shorter than I expected and smell of [].

You asked me to say what I take. I take the stairs at the corner of []. I take the sound of the shutters. I take one hour, around four, in which the light on the east wall is the color of the inside of a [].

I will return all of it. I only want you to know that in the meantime I have begun to speak with the accent of the place, and that when I say your name it comes out [].

Please do not ask who lent it to you first. I have looked. The name has been scraped from the deed, and under it, in a different hand, someone has written the single word *borrowed*.

Yours, very nearly,
[]

THE HYMN OF QUIET

Kofi T. · CC '18

In Ysmeine quiet is sung. The congregation meets
at the hour the bells were removed.

LEADER What do we keep?

ALL We keep the pause before the name.

LEADER What do we keep?

ALL We keep the door that did not slam.

LEADER Who sings it?

ALL Those who were asked to speak and did not.

LEADER Where is it held?

ALL In the lungs, between the breath and the
word.

*(Here the congregation stops. This is the hymn. It
lasts eleven minutes. Visitors mistake it for an
interruption.)*

LEADER And when the quiet ends?

ALL Then someone will say what we were afraid
to hear, and we will keep that too.

Strangers who stay for the second service say they
leave able to remember things that never happened
to them: a childhood by a lake, a mother's hand on
a banister, in a house they have never entered. The
sexton says this is the ordinary use of silence. It
is where the rest of us are stored.

THE RADIO OF BORROWED

Luca V. · CC '17

TRANSCRIPT, STATION 4, 2:00 A.M.

[static, rising]

ANNOUNCER: Good evening to the city of Halvane. It is, as it has been for some time, last Thursday.

[a bell, three times, none of them the same note]

ANNOUNCER: The weather. Yesterday's rain will fall at nine. Please keep your windows open for the part you missed.

[static]

ANNOUNCER: A message for the woman who left her name on the number 6 bus. It has been found. It is being kept at lost property under M. It is not clear which M.

[a child laughing, then the same laugh again, slower]

ANNOUNCER: Requests. Someone has asked for the song they heard in a kitchen when they were nine. We do not have it. We are playing instead a recording of someone looking for it.

[ten seconds of a person humming, stopping, starting again]

ANNOUNCER: This broadcast is borrowed from another city. We will return it at dawn.

[static, falling]

THE ALMANAC OF LATE

Sofia W. · Barnard '17

ESTRELLE CENTRAL: DEPARTURES

Trains leave on time. They leave earlier than you.

LISTED	LEFT	FOR
-----	-----	-----
6:10	5:55	anywhere
7:40	7:12	your mother's
9:05	8:50	the coast
11:15	10:30	here
last	--	--

The 6:10. You were still deciding.

The 7:40. Platform shown on the board, then removed.

The 9:05. Seats held in your name.

The 11:15. Arrived before it left.

The last. Not yet invented.

Passengers are advised to reach the station before they have decided to travel. Those who find themselves on the platform with a ticket they do not remember buying should proceed to the waiting room, where a clerk will explain that they have been traveling all along.

SLOW PROVISIONS

Gabriel J. · CC '15

HOW TO PROVISION A SLOW CITY

1. Begin in the evening. A slow city cannot be provisioned in the morning; it is not awake to receive you.
2. Take only what is already there. Bring a basket anyway.
3. Stand in the market until the vendors have stopped pretending to sell. Then buy one thing, whatever they are most ashamed of.
4. Carry it home the long way. In a slow city the long way is shorter. Nobody has explained why.
5. Do not cook. Set it on the table and let the room get used to it. After an hour the kitchen will begin to smell of whatever you were going to make.
6. Invite no one. Someone will come. They will have eaten.
7. Sleep. In the morning the city will have been provisioned. You will not remember doing it. This is how you know it was done properly.

If you find yourself hurrying, you have left the slow city. Turn around. It is exactly where you stopped.

UNLIT VOWELS

Ava W. · GS '15

The lamplighter walks the street at dusk, touching each lamp with his pole. Behind him the vowels go out, one by one, and the words stand dark in their windows.

Th lamplightr walks th strt at dusk, touching ach lamp with his pol. Bhind him th vowels go out, on by on, and th words stand dark in thir windows.

Th lamplghtr walks th strt at dusk, tuchng ach lamp wth hs pl. Bhnd hm th vwls g ut, n by n, and th wrds stand dark n thr wndws.

Th lmpghtr wlks th strt t dsk, tchng ch lmp wth hs pl. Bhnd hm th vwls g t, n by n, nd th wrds stnd drk n thr wndws.

Read it aloud. The lamps will come back on.

UNLIT LETTER

Daniel N. · SEAS '18

In Maraude the alphabet has a gap in it,¹ and everyone has learned to speak around it.² The old ones say it was never missing,³ merely unlit.⁴

¹ Between K and M. Schoolchildren are taught to leave a breath there, the length of one step on a staircase in the dark.

² Names that once contained the letter are spoken with a pause. Mothers call their children in from the street by calling out the pause.

³ The Registrar of Letters, when asked, produces a ledger in which every letter has an entry. The entry for this one reads, in full: *see above*.

⁴ A clerk sits every night at the foot of the Registry with a blank page and a sharpened pencil. This has gone on for sixty years. The page has never changed. The clerk says that is the entry.

⁵ For the full list of people who remember the letter, see note 3.

CONTRIBUTORS

Mira S. (GS '16) studies comparative literature. She has never arrived on time to anything and calls this research.

Samir T. (CC '16) is majoring in history and lives near the river. This is his first publication.

Clara K. (CC '16) writes at night and reads almanacs for pleasure.

Ilana M. (CC '18) is a first-year. She writes letters she does not send.

Kofi T. (CC '18) sings in two choirs and is writing about silence in a third.

Luca V. (CC '17) has worked at the campus radio station for two years.

Sofia W. (Barnard '17) studies architecture, which she says is mostly timetables.

Gabriel J. (CC '15) is a senior. He cooks badly and writes about it well.

Ava W. (GS '15) returned to school after some years away and has opinions about typefaces.

Daniel N. (SEAS '18) is studying engineering and keeps a notebook of footnotes he has not yet used.

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